

Report

Daily Learning Report

Topic: Microsoft Defender XDR (Day 2)

Date: 18/02/2026

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Goal of the Day

Begin the Pilot and Deploy journey for Microsoft Defender XDR by understanding its core components

- Understanding the role of each core component:
 - **Microsoft Defender for Identity**
 - **Microsoft Defender for Office 365**
 - **Microsoft Defender for Endpoint**
 - **Microsoft Defender for Cloud Apps**
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1. What I Actually Learned Today :

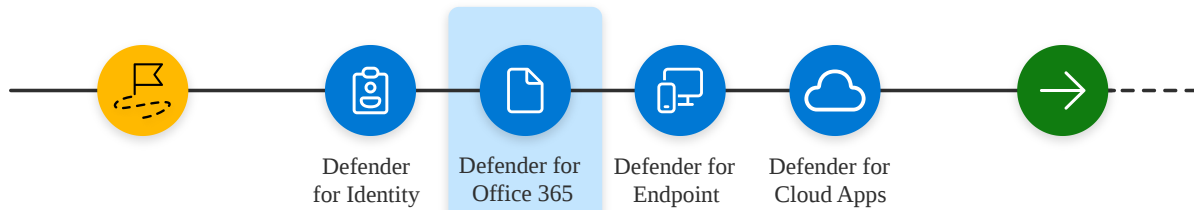
*** Pilot and deploy Defender for Office 365**

Pilot and deploy Microsoft Defender XDR

A Start the pilot

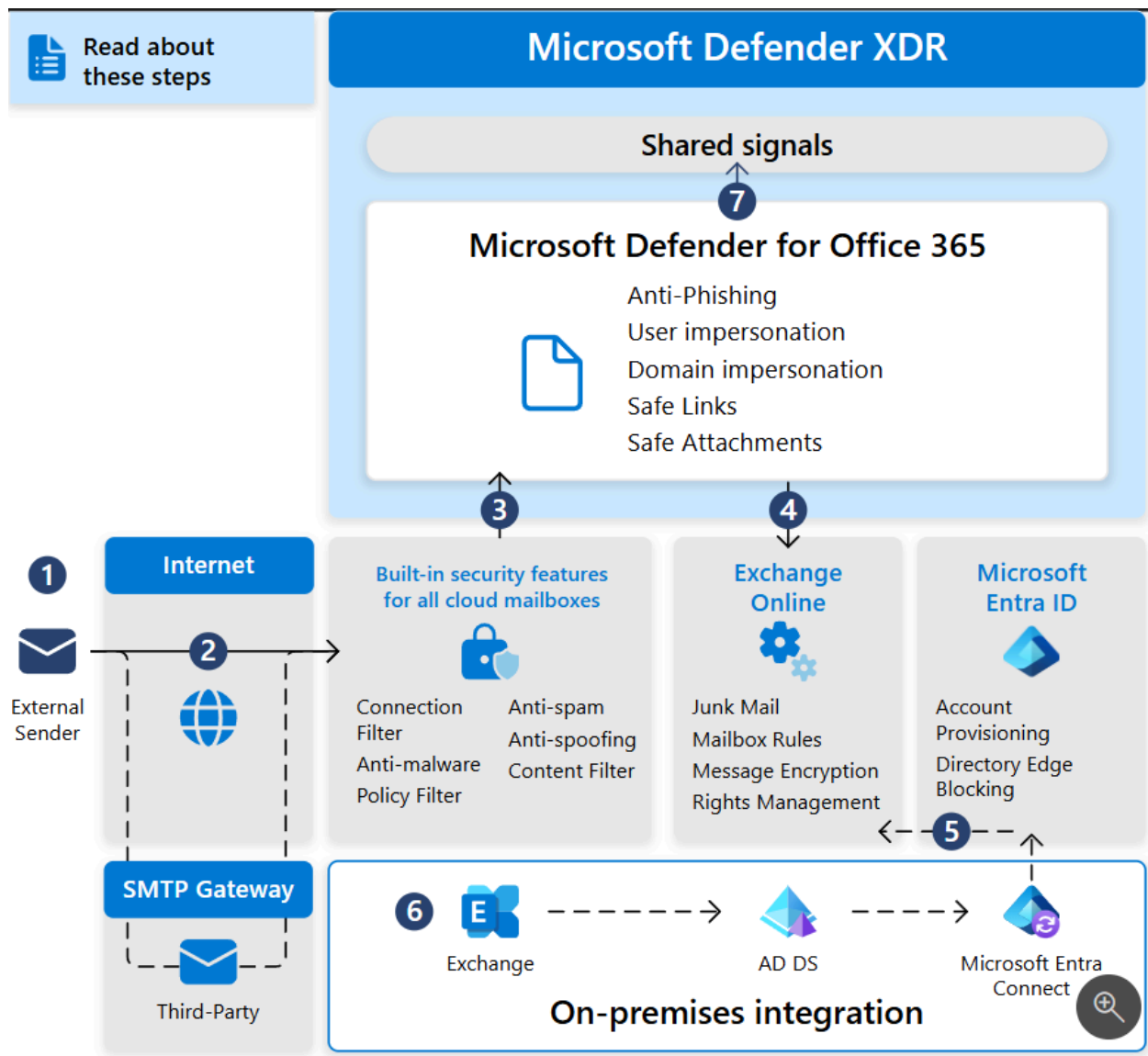
B Pilot and deploy Microsoft Defender XDR components

C Investigate and respond to threats



Defender for Office 365 architecture and requirements

This diagram illustrates the baseline architecture and key components of Microsoft Defender for Office 365



Step 1: Audit and verify the public MX record:

This step is checking **where incoming email for your organization actually goes**. tells all the to be send to a server you sepcify

"" here are the steps

1. In the M365 Admin Portal at <https://admin.microsoft.com>, expand ...Show all if necessary, expand Settings, and then select **Domains**. Or, to go directly to the Domains page, use <https://admin.microsoft.com/Adminportal/Home#/Domains>.

2. *On the Domains page, select your verified email domain by clicking anywhere on the entry other than the check box.*
3. *In the domain details flyout that opens, select the **DNS records** tab. Make note of the MX record that's generated and assigned to your tenant.*
4. *Access your external (public) DNS zone and check the primary MX record associated with your email domain:*
 - *If your public MX record currently matches the assigned address (for example, contoso-com.mail.protection.outlook.com) then no further routing changes should be required.*
 - *If your public MX record currently resolves to a third-party or on-premises SMTP gateway, then additional routing configurations may be required.*
 - *If your public MX record currently resolves to on-premises Exchange, then you may still be in a hybrid model where some recipient mailboxes haven't yet been migrated to EXO.*

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Step 2: Audit accepted domains

This step checks **which email domains your organization owns and how they are configured**.

- **Accepted domains** those are the domains that Microsoft 365 **recognizes as valid for an organization**.
- This tells Exchange Online and Defender for Office 365 **which emails belong to an organization** and how to handle them.

Step 3: Audit inbound connectors

This step checks **how emails are coming into Microsoft 365**.

it audits inbound connectors to verify that all incoming email is properly routed through Microsoft 365 so Defender for Office 365 can scan messages effectively

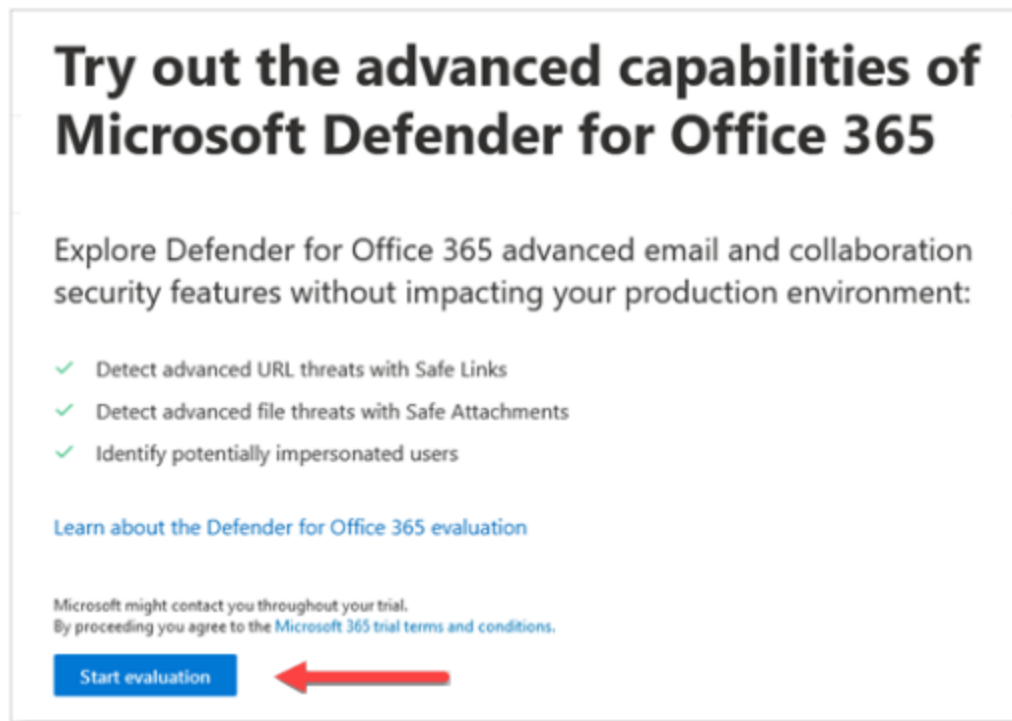
Step 4: Activate the evaluation

Activate Microsoft Defender for Office 365 evaluation from the Microsoft Defen here **turn on Microsoft Defender for Office 365 in evaluation (test) mode.**

here are the steps

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1. In the Microsoft Defender portal at <https://security.microsoft.com>, expand *Email & collaboration* > select **Policies & rules** > select **Threat policies** > scroll down to the *Others* section, and then select **Evaluation mode**. Or, to go directly to the *Evaluation mode* page, use <https://security.microsoft.com/atpEvaluation>.
2. On the *Evaluation mode* page, click **Start evaluation**.



3. In the *Turn on protection* dialog, select **No, I only want reporting**, and then click **Continue**.

Turn on protection

Bolster your defenses against phishing and other email threats by turning on blocking capabilities. With or without protection, we will provide you with a report as part of this trial so you can assess how Microsoft Defender for Office 365 protects your organization.

☐ Yes, protect my organization by blocking threats

☒ No, I only want reporting

Try Microsoft Defender for Office 365 in audit mode. Defender for Office 365 will not block emails with advanced threats, but you will be still able to monitor detected threats.

Continue

4. In the *Select the users you want to include* dialog, select **All users**, and then click **Continue**.

Select the users you want to include

Select the users that you want included in the Defender for Office 365 evaluation.

☒ All users RECOMMENDED

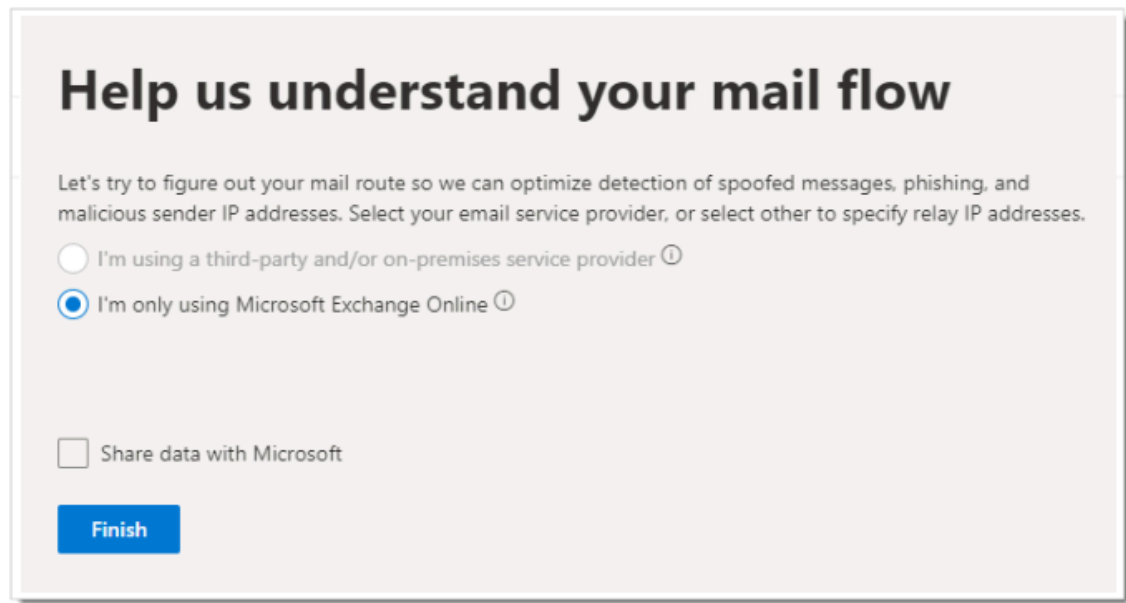
☐ Specific users

Continue

5. In the *Help us understand your mail flow* dialog, one of the following options is automatically selected based on our detection of the MX record for your

domain:

- **I'm only using Microsoft Exchange Online:** The MX records for your domain point to Microsoft 365. There's nothing left to configure, so click **Finish**.



Help us understand your mail flow

Let's try to figure out your mail route so we can optimize detection of spoofed messages, phishing, and malicious sender IP addresses. Select your email service provider, or select other to specify relay IP addresses.

☐ I'm using a third-party and/or on-premises service provider ⓘ

☒ I'm only using Microsoft Exchange Online ⓘ

☐ Share data with Microsoft

Finish

- **I'm using a third-party and/or on-premises service provider:** In the upcoming screens, select the vendor name along with the inbound connector that accepts mail from that solution. You also decide if you need an Exchange Online mail flow rule (also known as a transport rule) that skips spam filtering for incoming messages from the third-party protection service or device. When you're finished, click **Finish**.

Step 5: Create pilot groups

This part is about **controlling who gets which level of email protection during the pilot**.

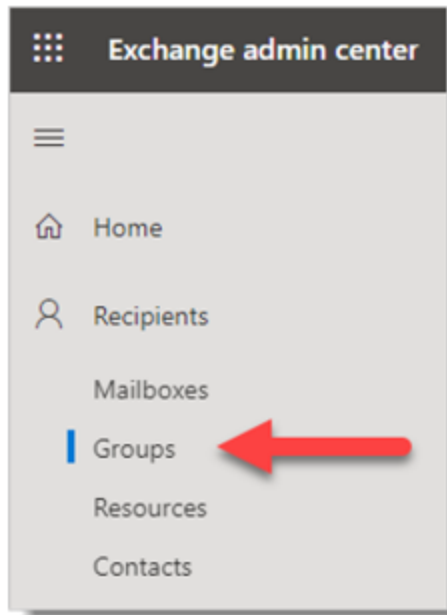
Instead of enabling Defender for Office 365 for **everyone at once** : we can **specify users or groups based on protection level**

Why use distribution groups?

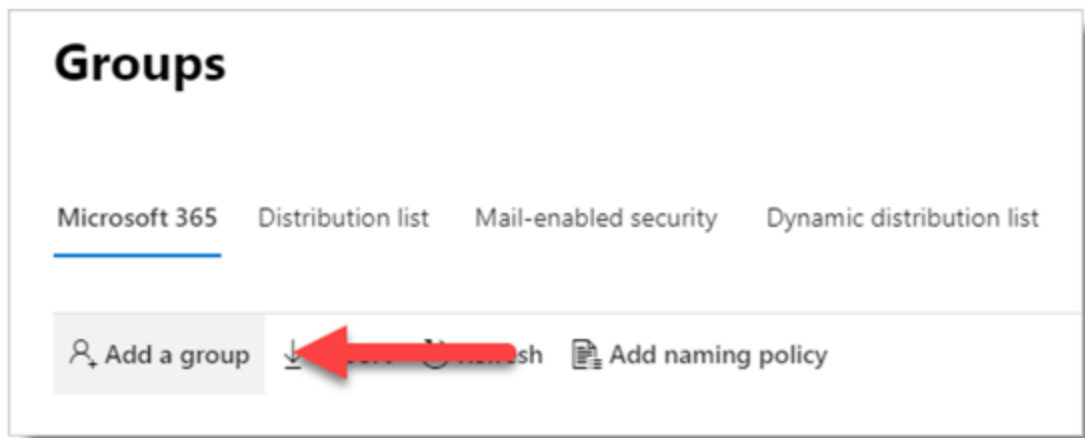
- They let us **apply different security policies to different users**
- They make it easy to **expand, change, or exclude users** during the pilot

here are the steps ""

1. Sign in to the Exchange Admin Center (EAC)
at <https://admin.exchange.microsoft.com> using an account that has been granted Recipient Administrator role or been delegated group management permissions.
2. Go to **Recipients > Groups**.



3. On the **Groups** page, select **Add a group**.



4. For group type, select **Distribution**, and then click **Next**.

Choose a group type

Choose the group type that best meets your team's needs. [Learn more about group types](#)

☐ Microsoft 365 (recommended)
Allows teams to collaborate by giving them a group email and a shared workspace for conversations, files, and calendars. In Outlook, these are called Groups.

☒ **Distribution** 
Creates an email address for a group of people.

☐ Mail-enabled security
Sends messages to all members of the group and gives access to resources like OneDrive, SharePoint and admin roles

5. Give the group a **Name** and optional **Description**, and then click Next.

Set up the basics

To get started, fill out some basic info about the group you'd like to create.

Name *

MDO Users - Standard Protection

Description

Group to assign MDO standard protection polices.

6. On the remaining pages, assign an owner, add members to the group, set the email address, join-depart restrictions, and other settings. """"

Step 6: Configure protection

This step is about **deciding how strong the email security should be** during the pilot.

Some configurations exist by default in mcirosoft 365 but security operations need more to raise thie level of security :

- Default are not enough for real attacks
- Security teams usually **increase protection levels**

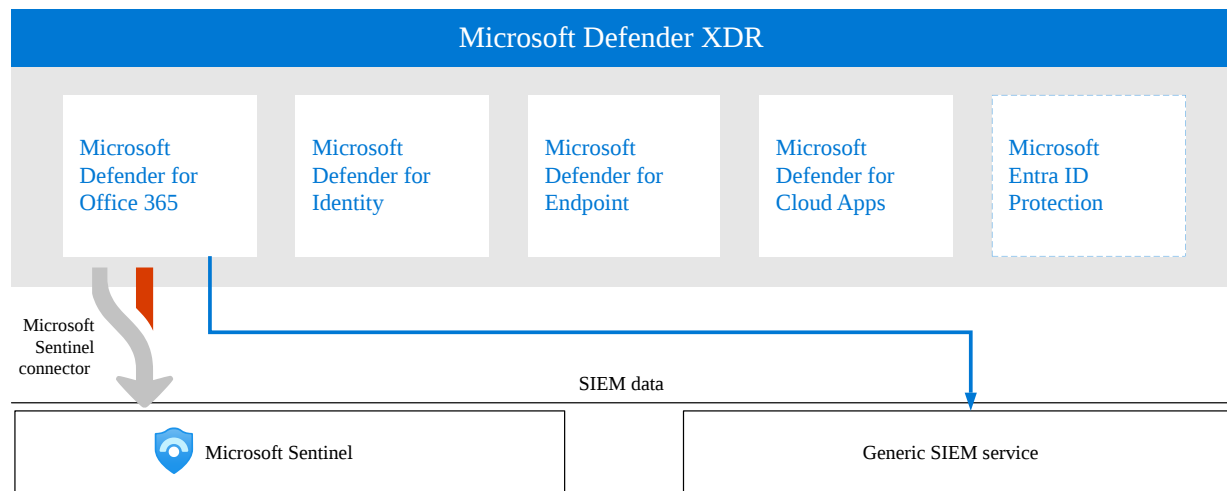
There are two ways :

1. **Preset security policies (recommended)**
2. **Custom protection policies**

Step 7: Try out capabilities

This phase focuses on validating Defender for Office 365 by testing detection, monitoring, investigation, and user behavior through reports, threat exploration, and attack simulations.

SIEM integration:



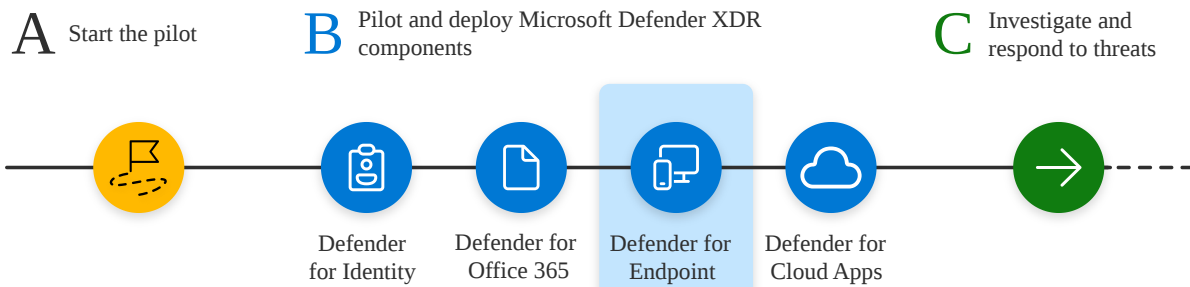
Microsoft Sentinel has a **built-in connector** for Defender for Office 365.

→ SIEM integration allows Microsoft Defender for Office 365 alerts and activities to be centralized in a SIEM platform such as Microsoft Sentinel, enabling organization-wide visibility, advanced analytics, and automated incident response.

*Pilot and deploy Microsoft Defender for Endpoint

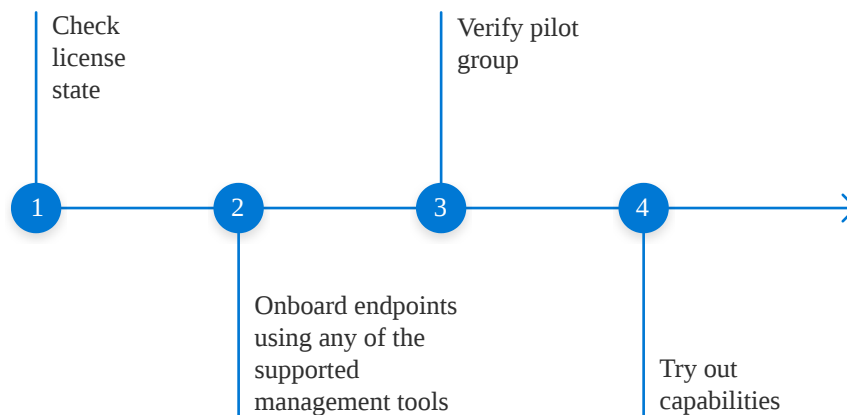
End-to-end deployment for Microsoft Defender XDR

Pilot and deploy Microsoft Defender XDR



Here is the workflow for piloting and deploying Defender for Endpoint in your production environment.

Pilot and deploy Defender for Endpoint

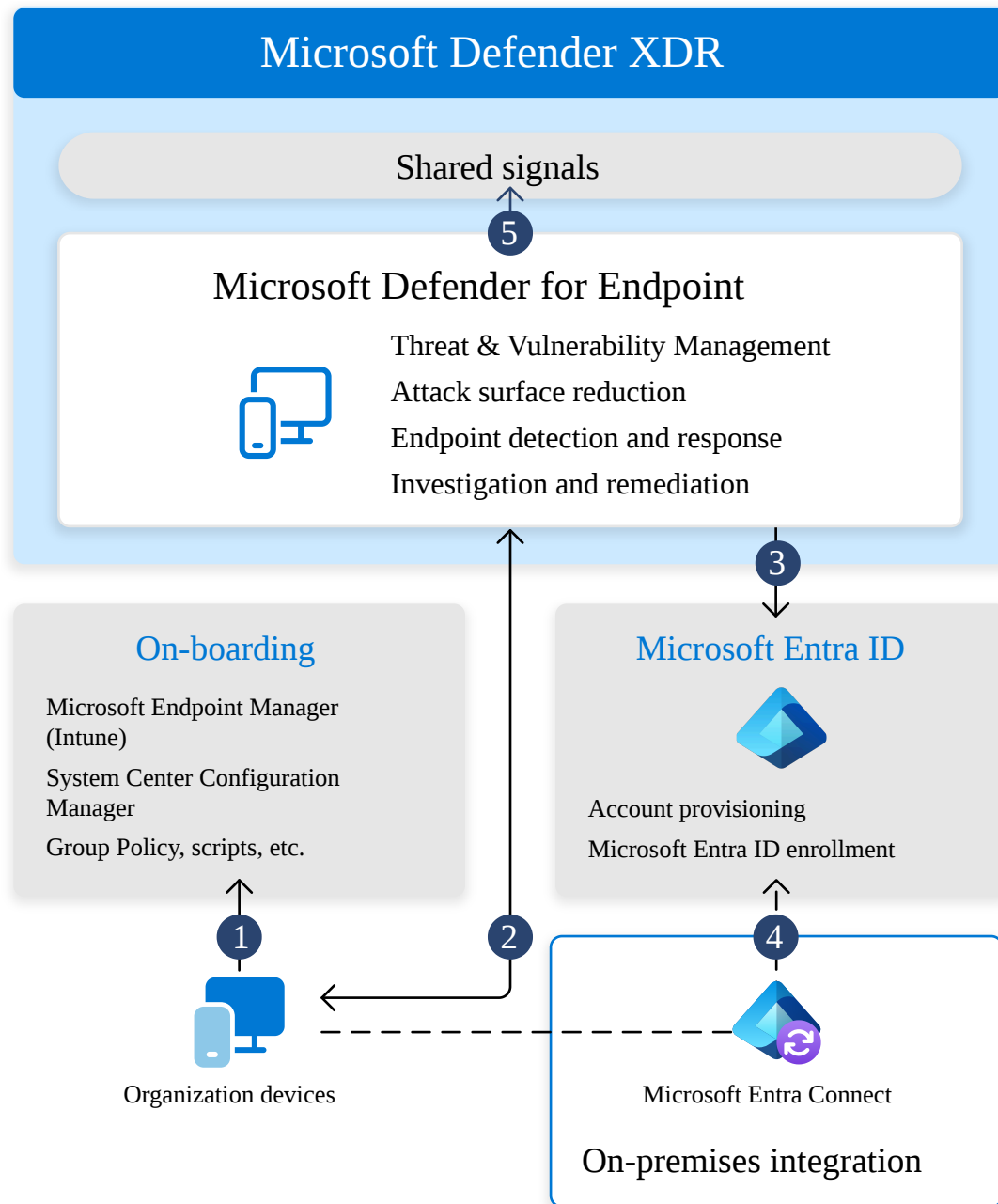


Here are the steps to follow

1. Check license state
2. Onboard endpoints using any of the supported management tools
3. Verify pilot group
4. Try out capabilities

Defender for Endpoint architecture

The following diagram illustrates Microsoft Defender for Endpoint architecture and integrations.



Here's an explanation for the illustration :

1)Device onboarding

Devices are registered with Microsoft Defender for Endpoint using supported management tools so they can be protected and monitored.

2)Security signal exchange

Onboarded devices continuously send threat telemetry and receive protection and response actions from Defender for Endpoint.

3)Microsoft Entra ID enrollment

Devices are joined or enrolled in Microsoft Entra ID to link endpoint security with user identity.

4) Hybrid synchronization

On-premises domain-joined devices are synchronized to Microsoft Entra ID using Entra Connect to enable cloud visibility and management.

5) Centralized security management

All alerts, investigations, and response actions are managed centrally in **Microsoft Defender XDR**.

STEPS IN DETAILS

Step 1: Check license state

First we need to check the license state to verify that it was properly provisioned

1. To view your licenses, go to the **Microsoft Azure portal** and navigate to the [Microsoft Azure portal license section](#).

NAME	ASSIGNED	AVAILABLE	EXPIRING SOON
App Connect	83	9917	0
Audio Conferencing	2398	97602	0
Audio Conferencing Unlimited (M...	10	324990	0
Azure Active Directory Premium P1	217343	0	0
Azure Information Protection Plan 1	211738	88262	0
Basic Collaboration	0	3000	0
Calling Plan Unlimited (MS Intern...	6	324994	0
Communications Credits	2327	9997673	0
Domestic and International Callin...	23604	76396	0

2. Alternately, in the admin center, navigate to **Billing > Subscriptions**.

On the screen, you'll see all the provisioned licenses and their current **Status**.

Licenses	
Available	1000000
Assigned ⓘ	0
Assign to users	

Step 2: Onboard endpoints using any of the supported management tools

For the purpose of evaluating Microsoft Defender for Endpoint, we can choose a couple of Windows devices to conduct the evaluation on.

Tools to onboard devices

Windows	- <u>Local script</u> (up to 10 devices)- <u>Group Policy</u> - <u>Microsoft Intune / Mobile Device Manager</u> - <u>Microsoft Endpoint Configuration Manager</u> - <u>VDI scripts</u>
macOS	- <u>Local scripts</u> - <u>Microsoft Intune</u> - <u>JAMF Pro</u> - <u>Mobile Device Management</u>

iOS	<u>App-based</u>
Android	<u>Microsoft Intune</u>

Step 3: Verify pilot group

We should see the devices in the Device inventory list approximately after an hour.

Step 4: Try out capabilities

After onboarding pilot devices, we can explore Defender for Endpoint's built-in features and dashboards to see threat detection, alerts, and security insights in action without complex configuration.

-Device Inventory: Lists all devices in the network with details like OS, domain, and risk level to identify high-risk endpoints.

-Vulnerability Management Dashboard: Shows device weaknesses, exposure scores, and top remediation actions to prioritize security fixes.

Run a simulation:

Microsoft Defender for Endpoint provides built-in, safe attack simulation scripts that can be run on onboarded pilot devices to simulate real attack scenarios and practice detection and investigation capabilities.

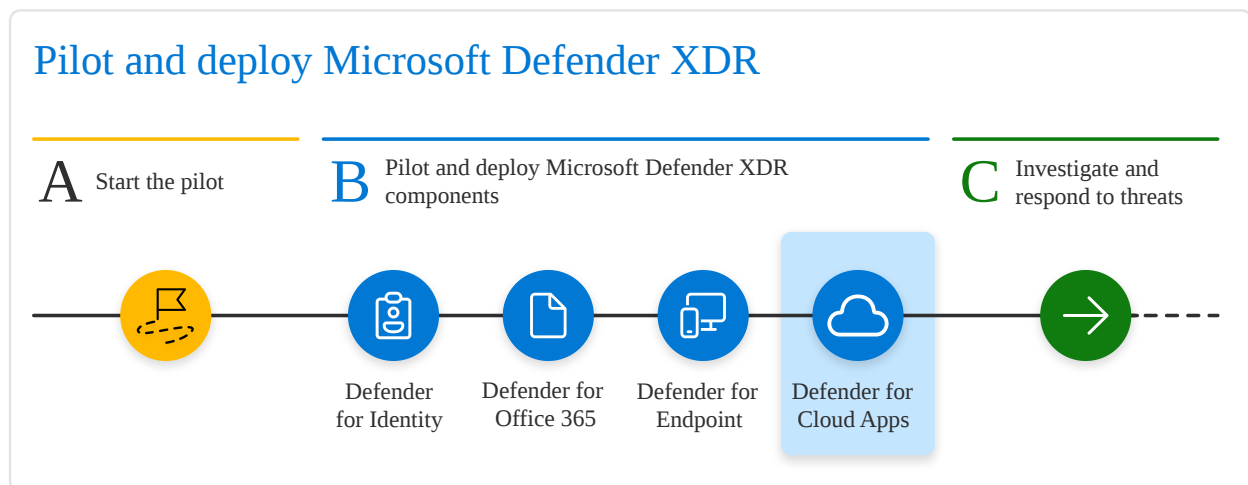
here are the steps to do this simulation ""

1. In **Help > Simulations & tutorials**, select which of the available attack scenarios you would like to simulate:
 - **Scenario 1: Document drops backdoor** - simulates delivery of a socially engineered lure document. The document launches a specially crafted backdoor that gives attackers control.
 - **Scenario 2: PowerShell script in fileless attack** - simulates a fileless attack that relies on PowerShell, showcasing attack surface reduction and device learning detection of malicious memory activity.

- **Scenario 3: Automated incident response** - triggers automated investigation, which automatically hunts for and remediates breach artifacts to scale your incident response capacity.
2. Download and read the corresponding walkthrough document provided with your selected scenario.
 3. Download the simulation file or copy the simulation script by navigating to **Help > Simulations & tutorials**. You can choose to download the file or script on the test device but it's not mandatory.
 4. Run the simulation file or script on the test device as instructed in the walkthrough document.

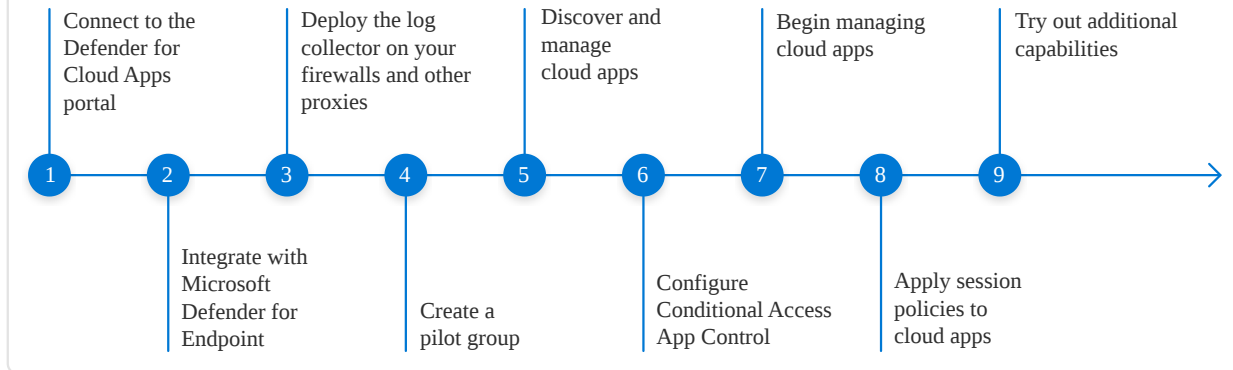
* Pilot and deploy Microsoft Defender for Cloud Apps

End-to-end deployment for Microsoft Defender XDR



Here is the workflow for piloting and deploying Defender for Cloud Apps in a production environment.

Pilot and deploy Defender for Cloud Apps



Here are the steps :

1. Connect to Defender for Cloud Apps
2. Integrate with Microsoft Defender for Endpoint
3. Deploy the log collector on your firewalls and other proxies
4. Create a pilot group
5. Discover and manage cloud apps
6. Configure conditional access app control
7. Apply session policies to cloud apps
8. Try out additional capabilities

Cloud app discovery methods:

Defender for Cloud Apps discovers and monitors cloud apps in your organization using two methods:

- Integrating with Microsoft Defender for Endpoint to collect cloud traffic from Windows devices
- Deploying log collectors on firewalls and proxies to capture traffic from all network devices.

Here's a direct link to the original version

https://www.notion.so/Report-30b2ef4ad9548013b634ff8dfc77c1e9?source=copy_link